

If all had gone well, DigiCash's ecash would have been integrated into all our web browsers at the ground floor, serving as the global Internet payment mechanism and potentially removing the need for credit cards in online payments. Sadly, mismanagement ultimately ran DigiCash into the ground, and in 1998 it declared bankruptcy. While DigiCash failed to become a household name, some players will resurface in our story, such as Nick Szabo, the father of "smart contracts," and Zooko Wilcox, the founder of Zcash, both of whom worked at DigiCash for a time.⁵

Other attempts were made at digital currencies, payment systems, or stores of value after ecash, like e-gold and Karma. The former ran into trouble with the FBI for serving a criminal element,⁶ while the latter never gained mainstream adoption.⁷ The pursuit of a new form of Internet money drew the attention of present day tech-titans such as Peter Thiel and Elon Musk, both of whom had a hand in founding PayPal. Except for Karma, the problem with all these attempts at digital money was that they weren't purely decentralized—one way or another they relied on a centralized entity, and that presented the opportunity for corruption and weak points for attack.

THE MIRACLE OF BITCOIN

One of the most miraculous aspects of bitcoin is how it bootstrapped support in a decentralized manner. The importance, and difficulty, of being the first currency to do so